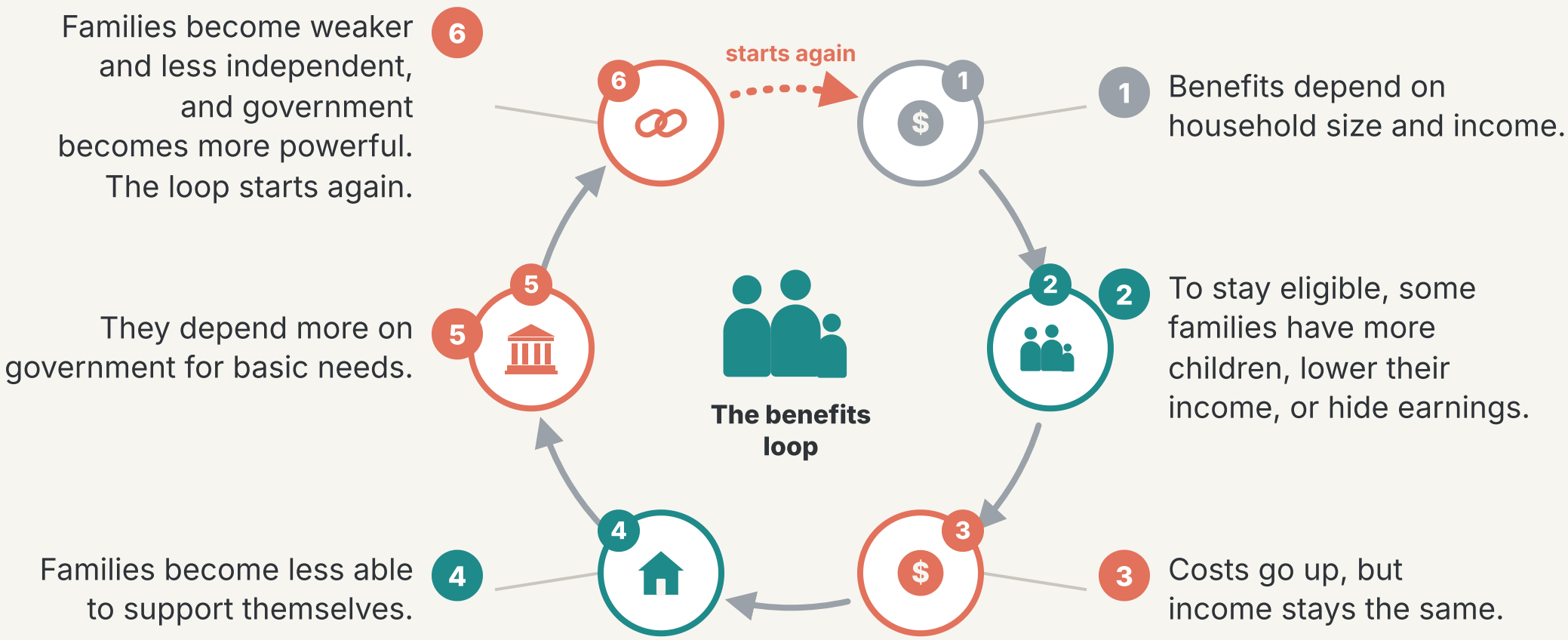
The Benefits Loop: How Eligibility Rules Can Keep Families Dependent

A hypothesis worth data analysis

THE LOOP, STEP BY STEP



KEY NUMBERS

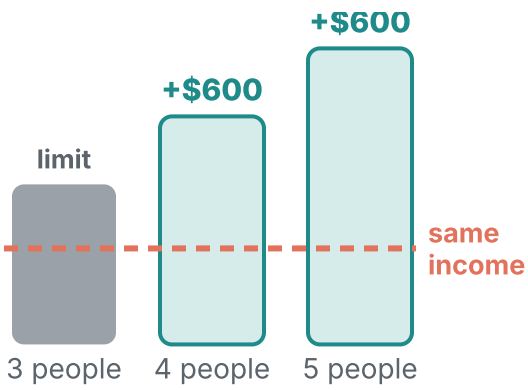
A child costs far more than the benefit adds

$200 a month, at most, in added SNAP food aid

$860 a month to raise a child

SNAP: FY2026, one more person, only at zero income. Child cost: USDA estimate for a lower-income family, 2015 dollars, higher today.

The income limit grows with family size



The SNAP income limit rises about $600 a month per added person, so a bigger family can stay eligible at the same income.

Some workers hold back to keep benefits



About 1 in 5 low-wage workers on benefits say they limit work or savings to stay eligible.

WashU survey, 2025

Sources: USDA FNS SNAP FY2026 allotments; USDA Cost of Raising a Child; Roll, Miller and Despard, WashU CSD 2025.